Chapter 22

Illegal Drugs

1. The Health Risks of Drug Use
2. Marijuana, Inhalants, and Steroids
3. Psychoactive Drugs
4. Living Drug-Free

Lesson 1 — The Health Risks of Drug Use

Substance abuse is the unnecessary or improper use of chemical substances for non-medical purposes. Drug abuse costs the U.S. economy an estimated **$1 trillion annually** (updated from textbook's $180 billion).

Fentanyl — The Most Critical Drug Safety Issue Today

Fentanyl is a synthetic opioid **50 times more potent than heroin** and 100 times more potent than morphine. Drug traffickers now press fentanyl into counterfeit pills that are visually indistinguishable from real prescription medications. **Fentanyl is now involved in approximately 75–80% of adolescent overdose deaths**. **8 in 10** teen fentanyl overdose deaths involve social media contact.

> Drug dealers actively use Snapchat, Instagram, and other platforms to sell counterfeit pills directly to teens. The rule is absolute: IF IT DID NOT COME FROM A LICENSED PHARMACY WITH A VALID PRESCRIPTION, DO NOT TAKE IT. Period.

Lesson 2 — Marijuana, Inhalants, and Steroids

Marijuana is now recreationally legal in roughly half of U.S. states — but it remains **federally illegal** and illegal for anyone under 21 everywhere. The legal landscape has changed since 2011, but the health risks haven't.

Regular teen marijuana use is associated with lower academic achievement, higher dropout rates, and increased risk of depression. The adolescent brain is especially vulnerable to THC — research shows it may permanently reduce IQ and impair memory formation.

Lesson 3 — Psychoactive Drugs

Stimulants	Speed up CNS: cocaine, meth, amphetamines. Cause heart problems, paranoia, addiction
Depressants	Slow CNS: barbiturates, tranquilizers, Rohypnol, GHB. Combining with alcohol is frequently fatal
Hallucinogens	Alter perception: LSD, PCP, psilocybin, MDMA (ecstasy). Cause dangerous behavior, heart failure, flashbacks
Opiates	Block pain, produce euphoria: heroin, morphine, oxycodone. Highly addictive. Now mostly fentanyl-contaminated.

Lesson 4 — Living Drug-Free

Most teens don't use drugs. About **83% of high school students** have never used marijuana; over **90%** have never used cocaine, heroin, or meth (2024 data). The 'everybody's doing it' line is statistically false.

Chapter Vocabulary

Lesson 1

Substance abuse	The unnecessary or improper use of chemical substances for non-medical purposes
Illegal drugs	Chemical substances that people of any age may not lawfully manufacture, possess, buy, or sell
Overdose	A severe, sometimes fatal toxic reaction to taking too large an amount of a drug
Addiction	A chronic brain disease involving compulsive drug use despite devastating consequences

Lesson 2

Marijuana	A plant whose dried leaves, buds, and flowers contain THC; now legally variable by state but illegal for minors everywhere
Inhalants	Substances whose fumes are inhaled to produce intoxication; can cause sudden death even on first use
Anabolic-androgenic steroids (AAS)	Synthetic hormones similar to testosterone; non-medical use is illegal and causes serious health damage

Lesson 3

Psychoactive drugs	Chemicals that alter CNS activity and change perception, mood, and behavior
Hallucinogens	Drugs that alter mood, thoughts, and sensory perceptions, causing hallucinations
Opiates	Drugs derived from or chemically similar to opium; highly effective pain relievers and highly addictive

Lesson 4

Rehabilitation	The process of medical and psychological treatment for physiological or psychological dependence on a drug